Benedikt Müller-Stewens

University of St.Gallen
Institute of Accounting, Control and Auditing
Chair of Controlling / Performance Management
Prof. Dr. Klaus Möller

2. Basics of Scientific Work

Accounting Forschung und Anwendung

"From insight to impact"

Learning Objectives

- This course introduces the different phases of scientific work. Thematically, particular attention will be paid to preparations of scientific work as well as special features during the writing phase.

- After processing this chapter, you should be able to answer the following questions:
  - What are the basic phases in the scientific work process?
  - Which points should be prepared before the writing phase?
  - What is the basic structure of a scientific paper and how can it change with different methods?
  - What are scientific criteria and what characterizes a scientific writing style?

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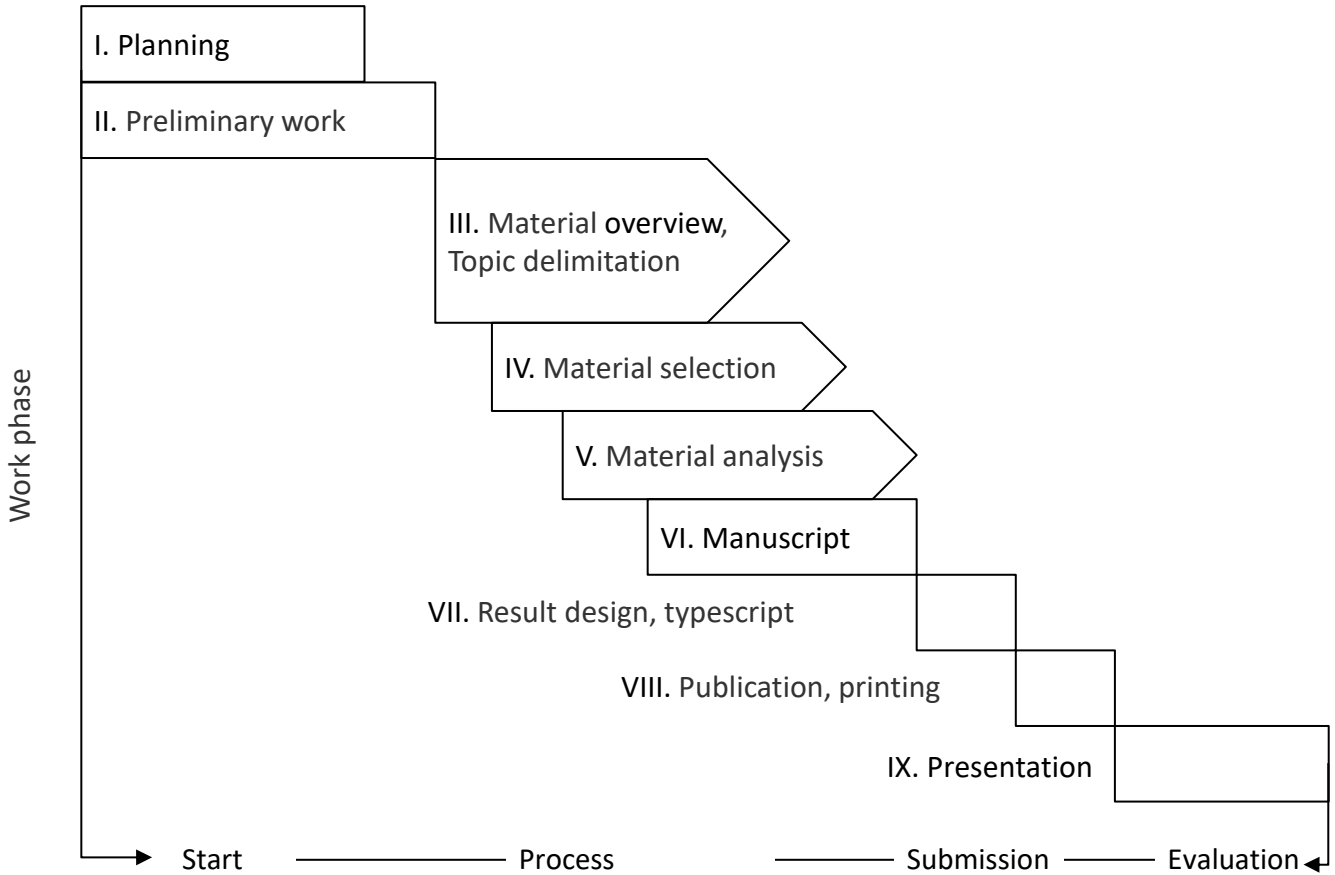
Table of contents: Phases of the scientific work process



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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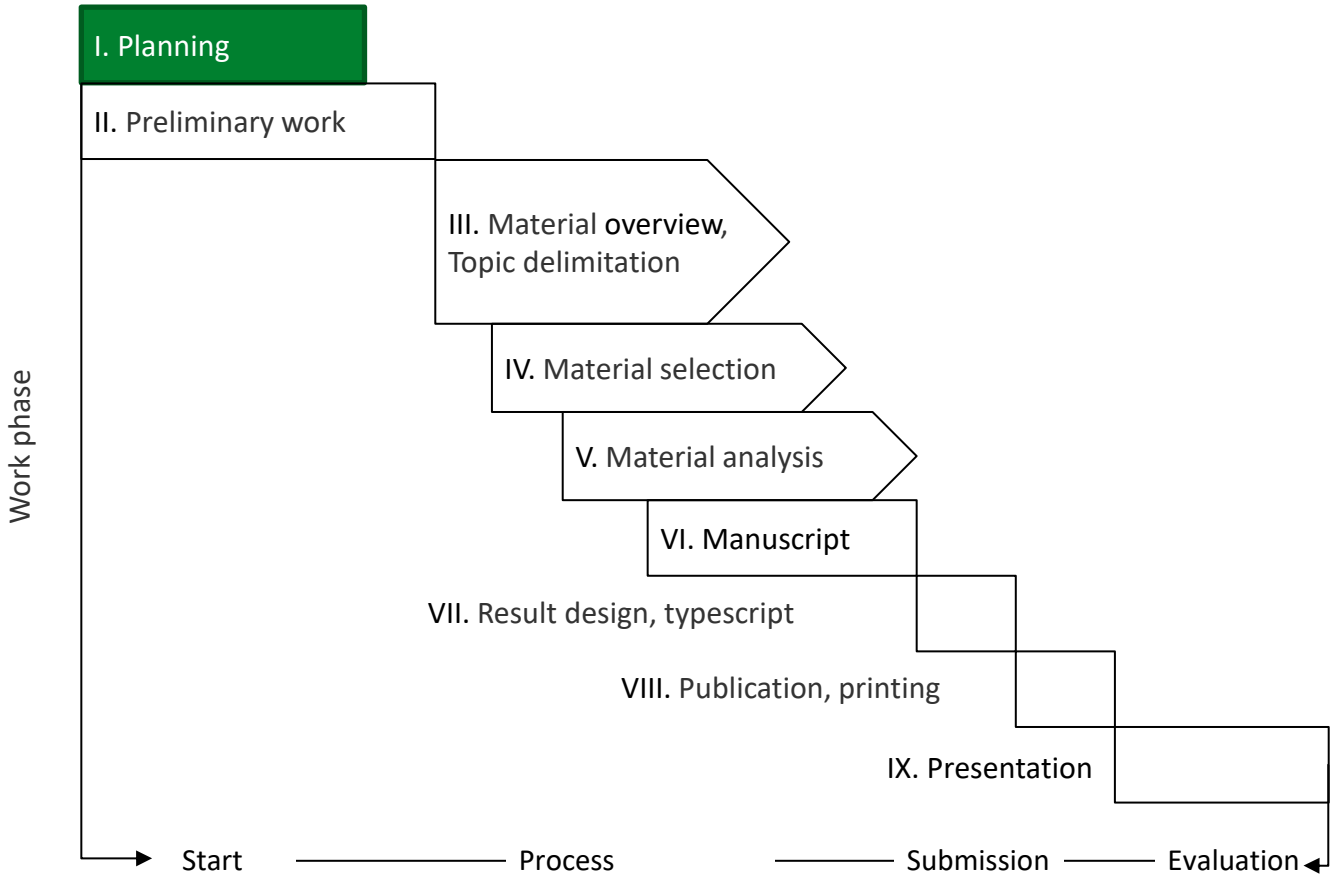

Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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I. Planning: part of the planning is the assessment of the writing situation

	Questions
Type of work	• What kind of work is it (seminar paper, final paper, etc.)? • Why are you dealing with the work (examination, final examination, voluntary consolidation, etc.)?
Task	• Is the topic given? Is it allowed to choose from several topics? • If given: What is the topic? Are there already specifications regarding content or editing method? • Who is the addressee and who belongs to the readership? What prior knowledge is to be assumed? • What are the time and formal requirements? • Is the work process already structured (possibly delivery of intermediate results)? • What support is allowed (e.g. discussions and access to materials)?
Time planning	• How much time does the work take? Is there a time window, if necessary? • How can the work be integrated into your own schedule?
Difficulties	• Are difficulties already foreseeable (e.g. information availability)?
Personal relationship with work	• What relationship exists to the given topic (prior knowledge and interest)? • What do you want to achieve when writing the paper (problem solving, better understanding, etc.)? • What are the own demands on formal and content-related quality? • With which strategies in writing papers could positive experiences already be made? Are there already mistakes that you would like to avoid repeating?

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 105.

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I. Planning: Sample project plan for the practical part of a master's thesis

		6	7	8	9	10
Aufgabenstellung						
1	Ausarbeitung der Aufgabenstellung	19.06				
	Vorstellung der Masterarbeiterin und Ausarbeitung einer Grobgliederung					
	Gegenseitige Abstimmung					
Konzept der Wertschöpfungsverwendungsrechnung (WVR)						
2	Überblick über die Vor- und Nachteile einer Veröffentlichung der WVR		25.07			
	Überblick über den derzeitigen Stand der WVR unter Einbezug von Best Practice Benchmarks sowie im nationalen und internationalen Vergleich					
	Präsentation gewonnener Erkenntnisse und gegenseitige Abstimmung					
Operationalisierung des Konzeptes						
3	Vorstellung passender Kennzahlen (Key Indicators) und Vorschläge für den gesellschaftl. Beitrag			13.09		
	Überblick über Anwendungs- und Operationalisierungsmöglichkeiten bei XY					
	Präsentation gewonnener Erkenntnisse und gegenseitige Abstimmung					
Finale Abstimmung der Ergebnisse					26.09	

Telefonkonferenz Zwischen den angesetzten Telkos können flexibel Absprachen eingerichtet werden

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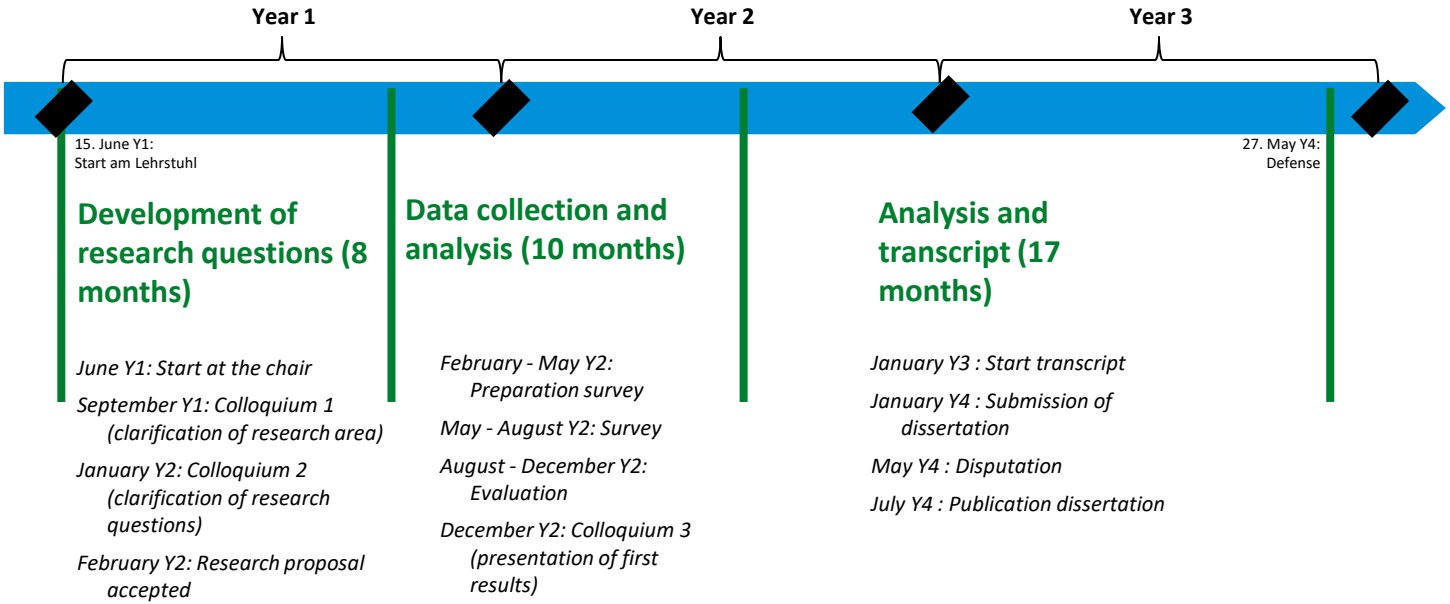
I. Planning: Dissertation



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I. Planning: Publishing process timeline

Conceptualization and data analysis

July 2014:
Conceptual idea

October 2014:
Master thesis

Spring 2015:

Data analysis

July 2015:

Submission of master thesis

Writing of the paper

July 2015 - October 2015:
Extending Analysis, adapting the framework, transforming thesis into paper.

Paper submission and review process

October 2015:
Paper submission to the Journal of Management Control

January 2016:
Invitation to prepare a major revision

March 2016:
Submission of the revised paper

July 2016:
Invitation to prepare a major revision

August 2016:
Submission of the revised paper

November 2016:
Invitation to prepare a minor revision

December 2016:
Submission of paper and confirmation of acceptance for publication in Journal of Management Control

January 2017:

First online version

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I. Planning: Publishing process timeline: An example requiring persistence

Conceptualization and Data Collection

Q3 2013:
Conceptual idea

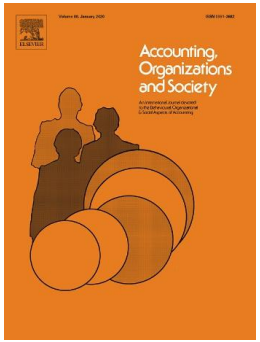
Q1 2014:
Questionnaire finished

September 2014:

Data gathered

Sept – March 2015:

Writing Manuscript



Writing of the paper

March 2015

ACMAR Doctoral Colloquium

April 2015

ISPIM Conference

Q4 2015

Research Stay Clemson (USA)

January 2016

AAA Conference (Rejected)

March 2016

Four Friendly Reviews

May 2017

EAA Conference

Paper submission and review process

January 2017
Paper submission to Management Accounting Research

1st Round Reject: *"both reviewers do not believe that the authors have demonstrated that the study makes a sufficient contribution to the literature to be published in MAR […] The motivation is not convincing. […] Theory development is weak. […] There are concerns with the method"*

June 2017:
Paper Submission to Accounting, Organization and Society

September 2017:
Feedback from AOS: "*Both reviewers like the topic of your study. At the same time, the reviewers express significant concerns with the paper and their recommendations are mixed."*

June 2018:
Resubmission to AOS

March 2019:
Feedback from AOS: *"The referees continue to be split as before, with reviewer 1 recommending rejection and reviewer 2 recommending revision. "*

September 2019:
Resubmission to AOS

October 2019:

Feedback from AOS: *"I found your response to be satisfactory."*

November 2019:
In press – online version available

January 2020:

Print version available

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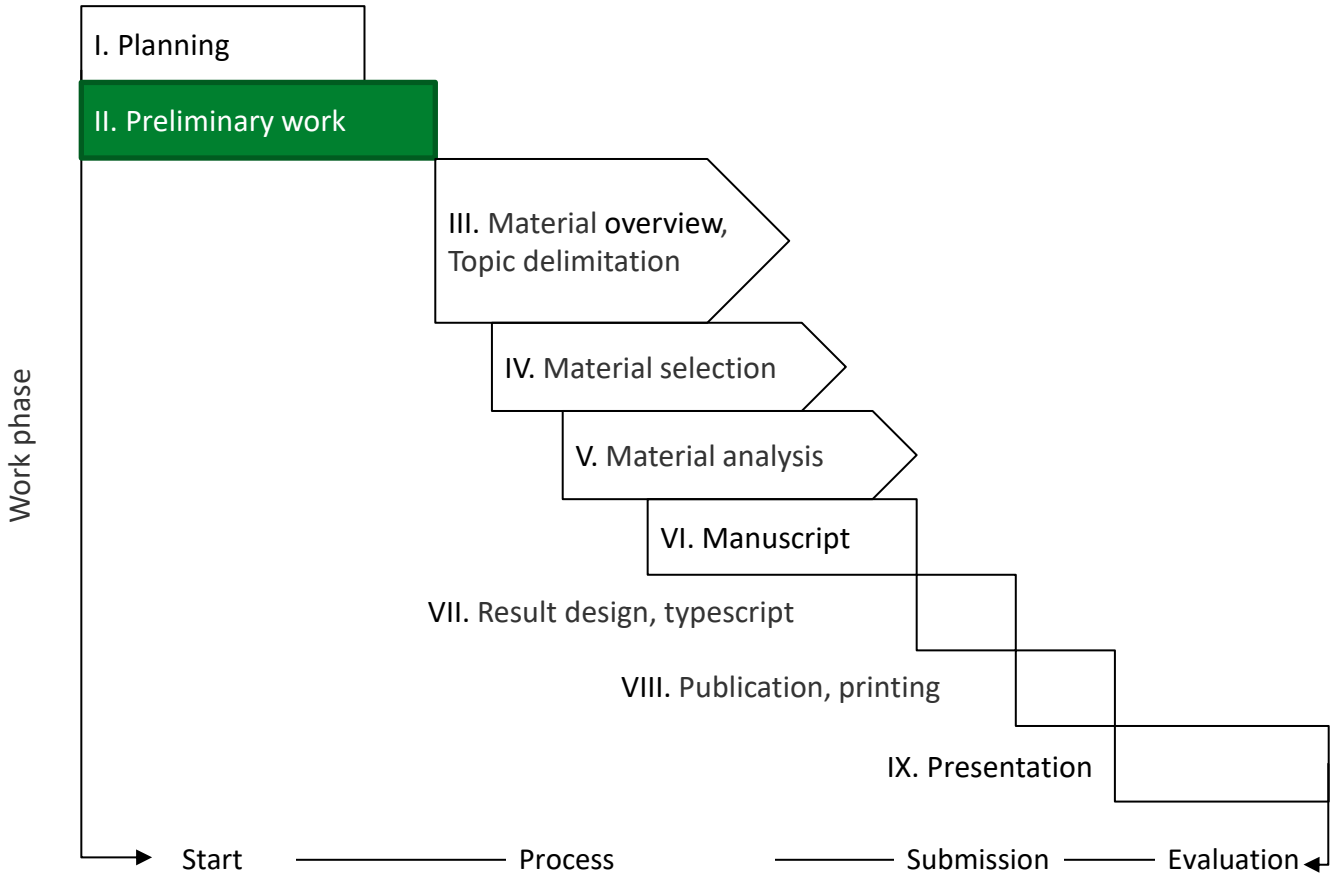
Table of contents: Phases of the scientific work process



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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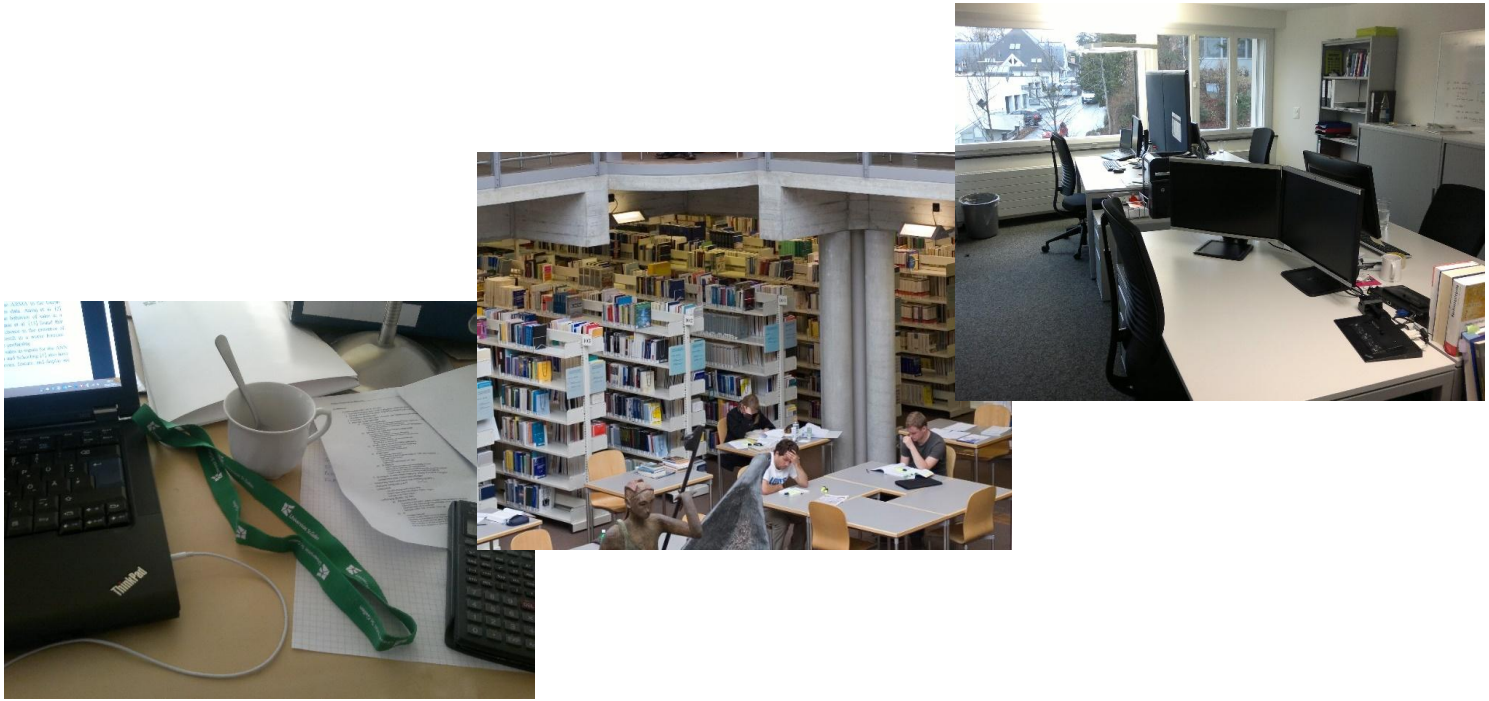
Preliminary work

- Preliminary work has a technical, but not yet a content-related reference.
- This includes the selection of workplace, work equipment as well as work technology and work organization.



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 45ff.

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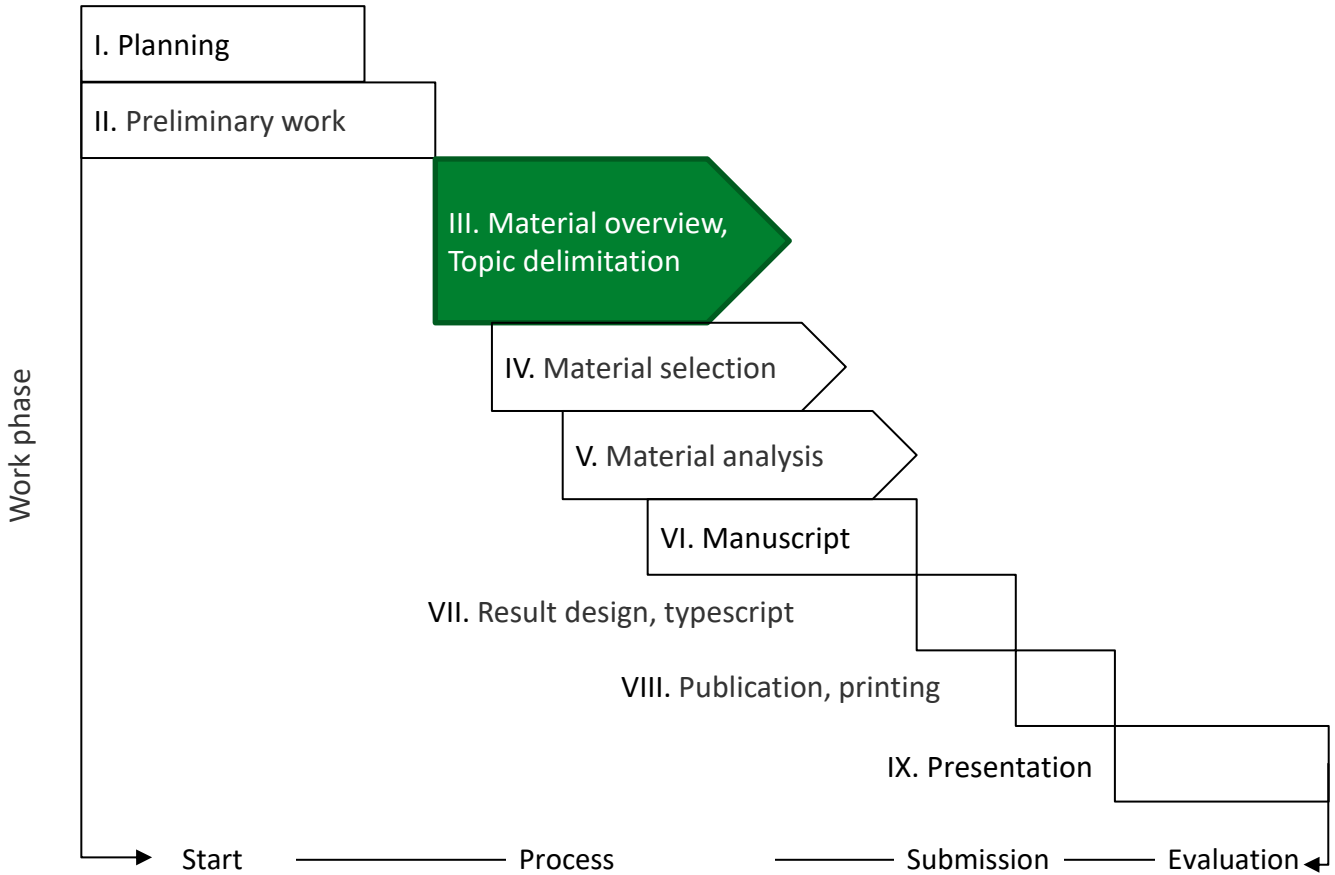

Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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Finding a subject

- issues from consulting/teaching
- debates in profession and business
- „further research“ calls in journal articles
- under-researched areas
- new theoretical or practice developments
- read, read, read

some advices

- take a risk
- neglected topics
- new, less used methodologies
- originality & freshness
- significance to the literature & society
- engage the reader

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III. material overview, topic delimitation Strategies for topic identification and delimitation.

Systematic approach

- Reference works
- Library catalogs
- Bibliographies
- Official publications
- Periodicals

Pragmatic approach

- Bibliographies
- Textbooks
- Commentaries
- Bibliographies of relevant literature
- Information databases
- Internet search

- Which method is more suitable also depends on the time available and the existing prior knowledge.
- A mixed strategy is recommended.

Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 60-88

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III. material overview, topic delimitation Formulation of the research question

The theoretical framework should already be defined. What is important now is the specification within the identified / specified topic field.
This avoids the superficial treatment of a large topic field.

Formulation and justification of the research question

Three steps

- Formulate specific topic
- Formulate a clear research question
- Theoretical, possibly also practical justification of the research question

Three guiding questions

- What is it about?
- What do you want to find out? What is new? What is not yet known about it?
- Why is the research question relevant to the reader? What do you want the reader to know? What do you want to ask the reader to do?

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III. material overview, topic delimitation Convincing motivation

What is convincing?

- Theoretical conflict
- Theories that are not fully specified
- Evidence does not fit the theory

What is not convincing?

- Lack of empirical evidence
- Not yet studied
- Practical relevance

Reisch, S. (2014), Organization Design.

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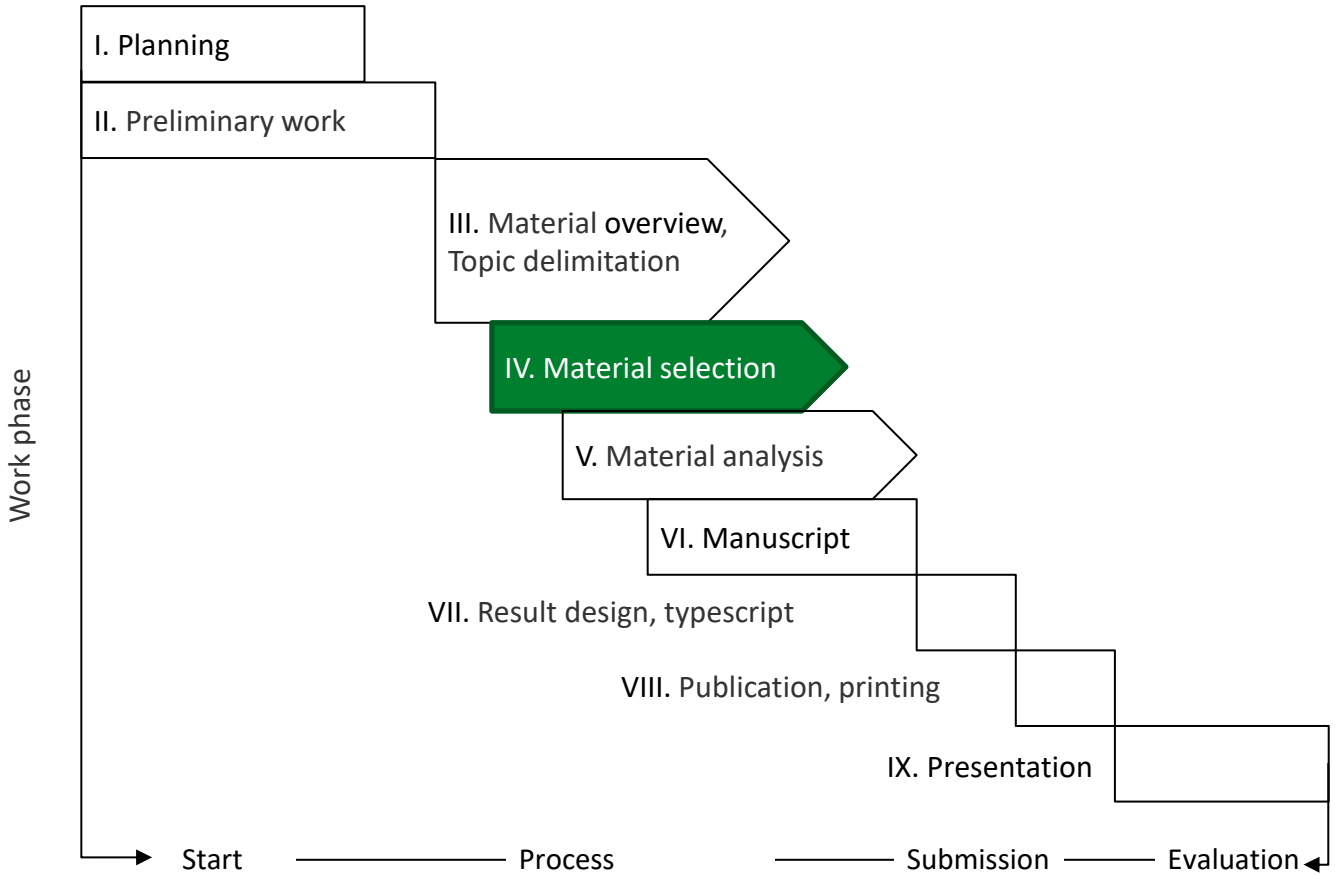
Inhaltsübersicht: Phasen des wissenschaftlichen Arbeitsprozesses



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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IV. Material selection: Evaluation of the sources

The central task in the material selection phase is the evaluation of the collected sources. They must first withstand a closer qualification and suitability test (see Module III).

Methods of selection / evaluation

Own test

- Testing of:
  - Title
  - Author
  - Publisher, Editors
  - Series
  - Journal
  - Publisher
  - Edition, Year of Publication
  - Foreword, Motto
  - Preface, Introduction
  - List of abbreviations
  - blurb, cover pages
  - Table of contents, abstract, outline, scope
  - Notes, quotations
  - Relationship of text to images
  - Bibliography
  - Audience

Reviews / Reviews

- Primary Sources:
  - Book reviews
  - Collective reviews in scientific journals
  - Review articles in journals

Closed-circle system

- Repeated search via primary and secondary sources in bibliographies until frequently cited literature is condensed:
  - Mixed form of own and external evaluation
  - Helps in finding the "core sources"
- Dangers:
  - Pursuit of circular reasoning in wrong area
  - Argumentation in circular reasoning
  - Neglect of interesting / new literature

Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 89-100

IV. Material Selection: Source evaluation and selection

- For scientific papers, articles by scientists for scientists are primarily recommended, although not necessarily exclusively.
- Academic journals examine articles submitted for publication in a peer review or even in double-blind reviews.

- E.g., Journals: Journal of Accounting Research, Management Accounting Research

- Journals can be judged by their editors or by their review process, which is often publicly explained.
- The position of an author in his research field is also informative.
- For books, use the most recent editions if possible.
- Primary sources should be used.

- E.g., Kaplan, R. S., Norton, D. P. (1996): The Balanced Scorecard: Translating Strategy into Action, Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

- In the case of books, the most recent edition should be used if possible.

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 114.

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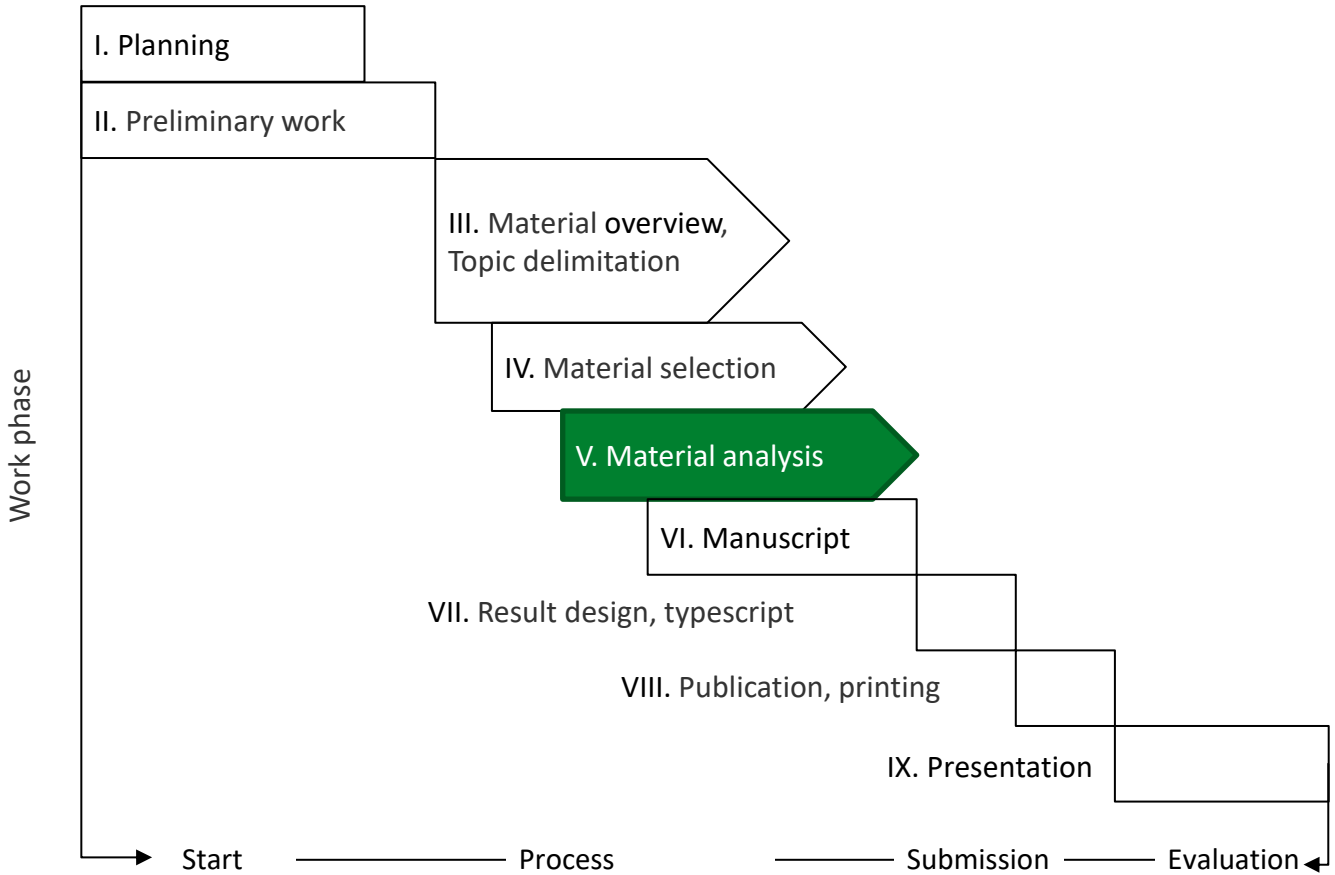
Table of contents: Phases of the scientific work process



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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V. Material evaluation: Structuring the source compilation

After the material search, it is recommended to record all sources and all material and to put them in a structural order.

Recording of all relevant source data for the bibliography

- Serves for easier usability and saves later formalization effort;
- Software for literature management: EndNote, Citavi, Mendeley or Zotero.

Classification of sources can be based on their relevance/affiliation within the research (e.g., classifying whether source is original theory or a further development)

- Preparation for the theory part of the paper (literature review + rendition of the state of research).

Not only sources, but also content and results can already be classified along the thread.

- A formal outline started early facilitates the weighting of the main points as well as the formation of the later structure

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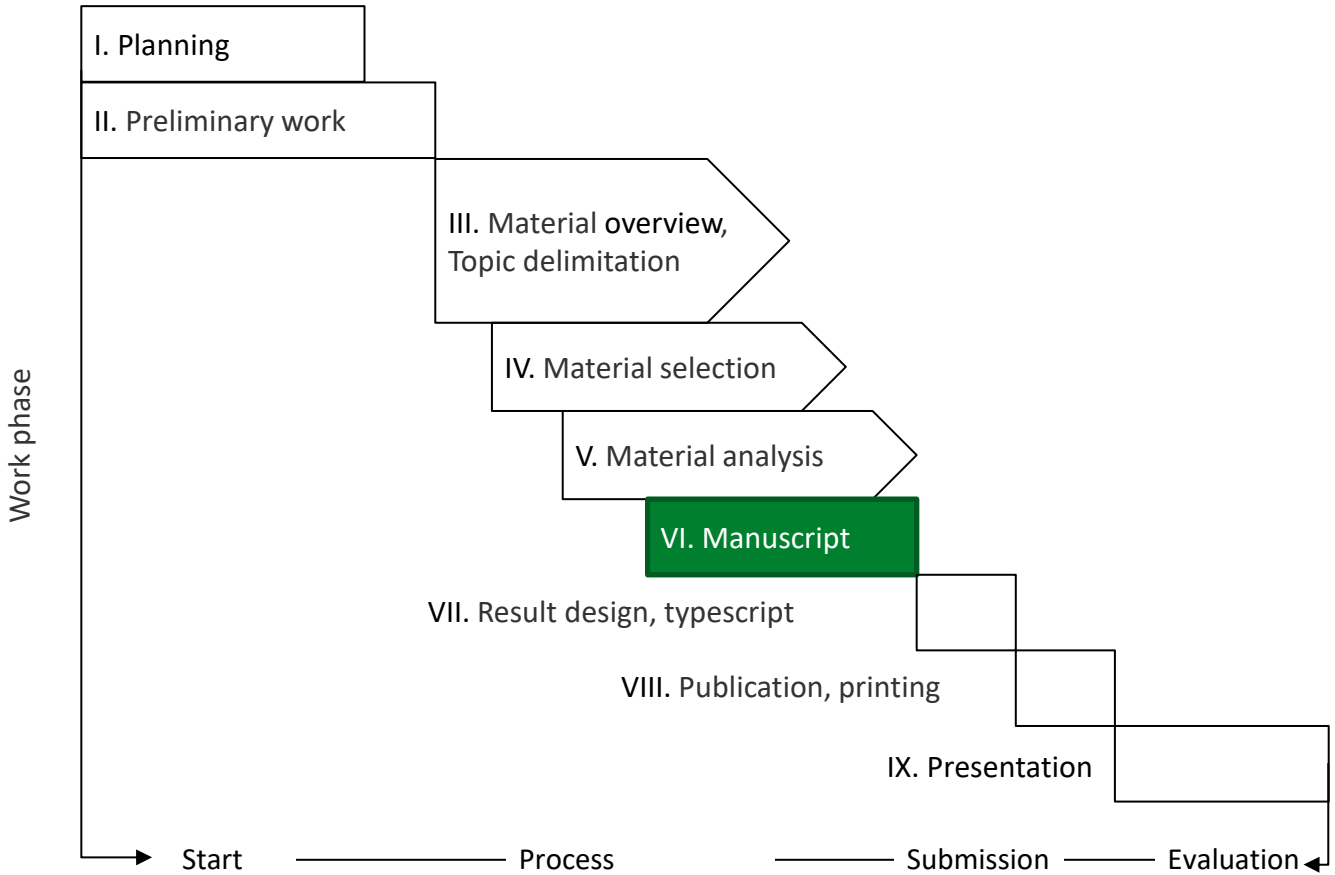

Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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VI Manuscript phase

With the previously described phases, the research phase is complete. The manuscript phase can now be further subdivided:

- A first sorting has already been done in the material evaluation. This rather formal sorting is now extended by the content component.
- In a good paper, the content is already recognizable by a glance at the table of contents.
- Outlining and structuring principles should be observed; they facilitate the following writing phase.

In Anlehnung an Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 104, 119-120, 143
In Anlehnung an Theisen, M. R. (2013): Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 147ff.

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VI. manuscript structuring

- The structure should represent a logical sequence and be comprehensible for the addressees.
- A maximum of three (sub)levels of structuring are recommended (see figure).
- The criterion of rigor means having a common thread and following it.
- Appropriate weighting gives sufficient space to the relevant aspects.
- All content should be related to the research question.
- Each level has at least two sections: At least two chapters, subchapters, etc.
- Outline principles:
  - Building a chain of argumentation
  - Comparison criteria
  - Temporal or factual order
  - Whole and its parts (classification, relationship)
  - Process of an empirical research design
  - Problem solving process
  - Chain of causes and effects
  - Logical principles: Deduction or induction

1. Introduction
   1. Problem
   2. Research Question
   3. ...
2. Theoretical foundations
   1. Definition
   2. Underlying theory(s)
   3. ...
3. Main body
   1. Research method X
      1. Structure of the investigation
      2. Aims of the investigation
      3. Implementation
      4. ...
   2. Evaluation of the results
   3. Relation of the results to the problem
4. Conclusion
   1. Summary
   2. ...

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 120.

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VI. Manuscript: Abstract

Abstract

- Write only at the end
- Usually directly after the title(sheet)
- Short and compact, main findings in a single sentence
- Helpful in the phase of early topic research
- General structure: background, method, results, conclusion
- Background: Why at all?
- Method: What approach?
- Results: What result?
- Conclusion: What conclusions?

Sometimes the structure is given

- 250 words or less (no more than 100 in any one section)
- Purpose – Reasons/aims of paper
- Design – Methodology/'how it was done'/scope of study
- Findings – Discussion/results
- Research limitations/Implications – Exclusions/next steps
- Practical implications – Applications to practice/'So what?'
- Originality/value – Who would benefit from this and what is new about it?

www.emeraldinsight.com/structuredabstracts

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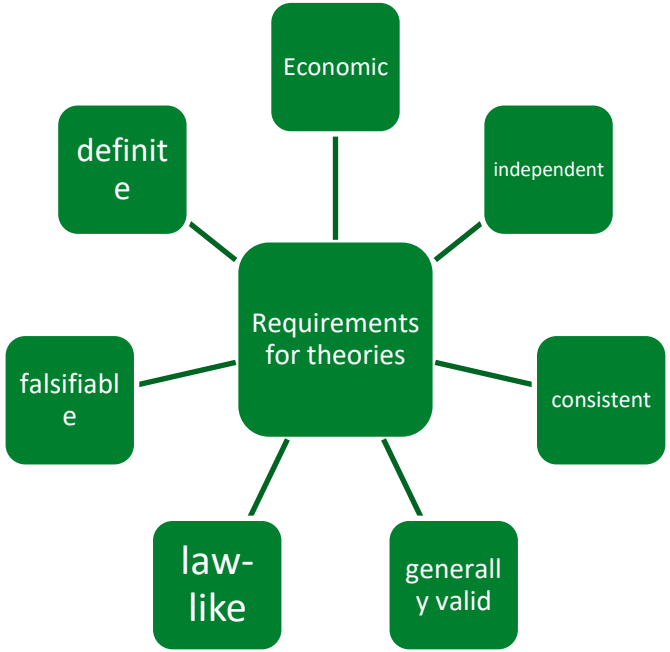
VI. manuscript introduction

The introduction leads to the topic in a problem-oriented way and should arouse the reader's interest. The length of the introduction should be <5% of the total length of the paper.

Sequence of the introduction

- Familiarize with the background, but not too detailed, and take into account the reader's previous knowledge.
- Then present the main focus
- If necessary, formulate thesis; the requirements of theorizing apply.



In addition, give details of

- Objectives of the paper
- Theory used
- Own position
- State of research
- Research design
- Data used in analyses
- Structure of the work

Metzger, J. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Sauerländer, S. 133.

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VI. manuscript main part

The main part is dedicated to the research question and contains the innovative element or develops the new. The subchapters of the main section also follow the scheme of introduction - main section - conclusion, at least in terms of content.

The previous structuring should facilitate the writing.

To note in the main body:

- For each subsection, first introduce the reader to the main idea as a kind of thesis.
- In the following, thoroughly substantiate and explain the main idea
- Observe correct and logical argumentation, depending on deductive or inductive approach
- Follow step by step, logical thought and argumentation

What is publishable? (empirical example)

Traditional format:

- Problem
- Literature
- Research method / methodology
- Case(s)
- Discussion
- Conclusion

Main part

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 135-136.

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VI. manuscript conclusion

The conclusion should address the research question developed at the beginning of the paper (ideally not verbatim) and reflect the m**ost valid answers and arguments**. The answers are **embedded in the scientific literature**. Outline how this addresses the research gap outlined and thus makes a **theoretical and practical contribution**.

To be noted in the conclusion:

- Closing the circle to the introduction.
- Point out open questions and further research possibilities
- Keep the conclusion short and to the point
- Do not add any new information to the argumentation.
- Remain objective, no pathetic résumé
- Do not generalize beyond the findings developed

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 137.

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VI. manuscript argumentation: elements of an argument

Thesis	• is an assertion that expresses a point of view (position), a claim, a demand, or main idea.
Justifications	• support the thesis via theoretical and empirical evidence, proofs (evidences) and conclusions.
Limitations	• relativize or specify the thesis by means of limiting conditions, exceptions, admissions, etc. and corresponding justifications.
Premises	• are fundamental assumptions (values, norms, general experiences, convictions, general principles, etc.) that underlie a thesis and justification as a deeper justification.

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 117.

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The reasoning is full of pitfalls....

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VI Manuscript: Errors to avoid in argumentation and search for results

Overgeneralize	E.g.: generalize empirical studies in certain territory to other part of the world.
Jumping to conclusions	E.g.: drawing conclusions or arguing on the basis of personal experience and without further support.
Linking without permission	E.g.: linking different research results if they are incompatible
Forming false causal relationships	E.g.: Correlation vs. causality - not everything that follows later in time is causal
Use false dichotomies	E.g.: do not assume only two possibilities as possible solutions, if there are intermediate stages

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 136.

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Writing style tips

- Active language, i.e., no nouns
- Short, simple, precise expression
- Observe the style of the chosen publication you are targeting
- Observe the perspective of the author
- Create reading flow through sentence structure, variation of sentence length, etc.
- Do not use too many passive constructions
- Do not use discriminating words, observe usage of masculine/feminine form

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 139.

VI. manuscript writing style: author's perspective
A wording problem exists regarding the inclusion of the author.

- In the case of an author, either the "I" form or the third person ("the author") should be used, depending on the usage. However, both forms should be used extremely sparingly.
- The plurale maiestatis ("we") should be avoided.
- In the case of communities of authors, however, the "we" is permissible.
- It is recommended to use an unobtrusive, impersonal form (e.g. according to this recommendation).

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 139.

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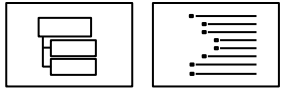
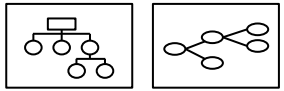
VI Manuscript: Representations for better understanding

- Tables with qualitative and quantitative data concentrate data in a small space.
- Figures are representations that cannot be presented in tabular form. They usually have a lower level of detail.
- Care should be taken to ensure that they are positioned appropriately in the text.
- Illustrations should be referred to in the text; even data in the appendix should be mentioned.
- Central information can also be presented schematically in addition to the verbal explanation.

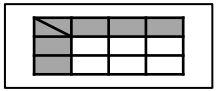
- Elements, features



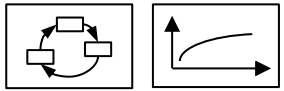
- Superordination/subordination



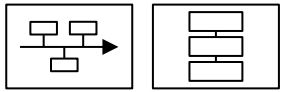
- Comparison / Assessment



- Relationships



- Sequence, procedure



- Combinations of representations

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 63, 141.

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VI Manuscript: Proper Citation: Two citation methods

	Verbatim quote	Implied citation
Content	Several types of facts and statements: numbers, names, continuous text, tables as well as figures	
Purpose	Emphasize authenticity of information or emphasize its importance	Paraphrasing: Paraphrasing information in one's own words of approximately the same scope as the original. Summarize: reduce extensive information to its essentials in your own words
Frequency	Rarely	By type of work frequently to rarely
Scope	One or more words, part of a sentence, several sentences	When paraphrasing, refer to a part of an information source. Paraphrasing can be used to summarize sections, chapters, tables, etc.
Presentation	Quotation marks	No quotation marks
Documentation	According to selected standard	According to selected standard

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 125-126.

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University of St.Gallen

Documentation accompanying the text

- Depending on the citation guideline applied (APA, MLA or derivatives thereof), the corresponding source must also be mentioned for the adopted text passage. The source is either integrated into the text or reproduced in footnotes or endnotes.

Documentation following the text

- The sources used and cited in the text are also included in the bibliography located at the end of the paper.

Bibliographic and informative notes in footnotes

- Information that would complicate the text but is still relevant is reproduced in informative footnotes. Extensive material is instead moved to the appendix.
- Bibliographic footnotes may refer to sources that have not been directly utilized in the text. Such sources may also be annotated (e.g., "Disagree with...").

Metzger, C. (2008): Lern- und Arbeitsstrategien, 10. Aufl., Oberentfelden 2008, S. 130.

VI. Manuscript: Common errors for publication of submitted manuscripts

	Type of error	Frequency
A	**Linguistic errors:** Long / incorrect sentences or phrases Missing and inappropriate words Incorrect grammar Ambiguous or unclear statements	86%
B	**Scientific content deficiencies:** Ambiguous statements Undefined concepts Unclear or incomplete argumentation Failure to cite known scientific findings Lack of comparison to other work Unclear contribution to the scientific topic Wrong conclusions	80%
C	**Style error:** Incomplete citation or citation of sources not in accordance with the standard. Abstract not conforming to standard (too long, unclear, etc.) Missing keywords or citation Inappropriate title Non-compliant structure of the article	77%
D	**Other errors:** Missing punctuation Orthographic errors Uncited sources used Format errors	59%

Frentiu, M., Pop, H. F. (2010): Editorial: Common mistakes in wiriting a scientific paper, in: Studia UBB INFORMATICA, Vol. 55, No. 4, 2010.

VI Manuscript: Scientific quality criteria

Scientific quality criteria

- Objectivity
- Honesty
- Verifiability
- Reliability
- Validity
- Comprehensibility
- Relevance
- Logical reasoning
- Originality
- Comprehensibility

Balzert et al. (2008): Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten - Wissenschaft, Quellen, Artefakte, Organisation, Präsentation, W3l, S. 9.

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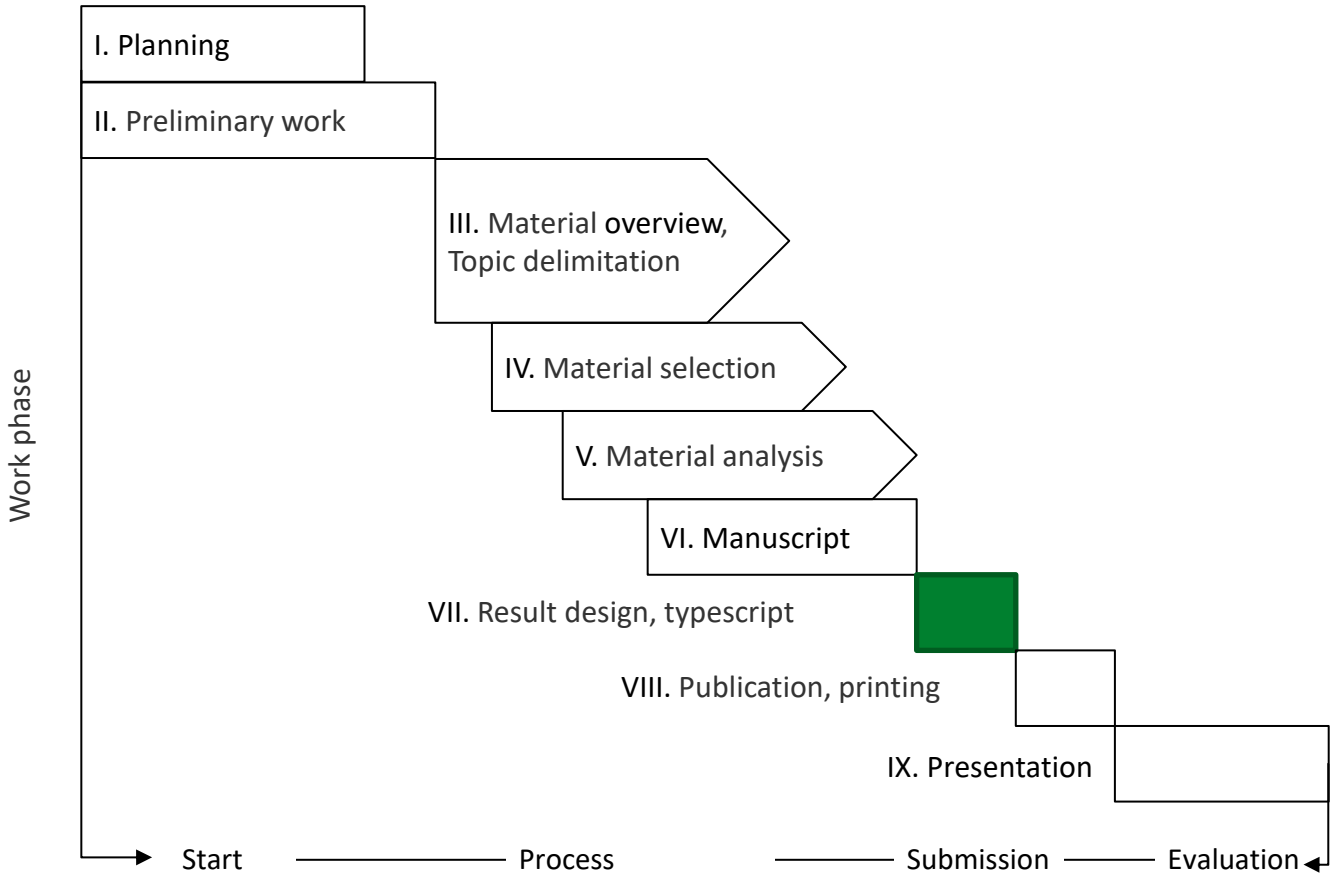
Table of contents: Phases of the scientific work process



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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VII. result design, typescript: Result design and formal requirements

Cover page

Separate page: title, name, type of work, institution, place, date

Abstract

Table of content

List of abbreviations, tables and figures

Formal considerations include page margins, line spacing, font size, font alignment, etc.

Main part

Number appendix;contents should be mentioned in the text

Literature

Appendix

Possibly observe Roman / Arabic page counting (Arabic 1 begins with the text);Do not include abstract.

Rules for citation in the bibliography depending on the standard

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VII. result design, typescript: For work at the chair there is a guideline not only regarding citation guidelines

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Zitierrichtlinien

des Lehrstuhls für

Controlling / Performance Management

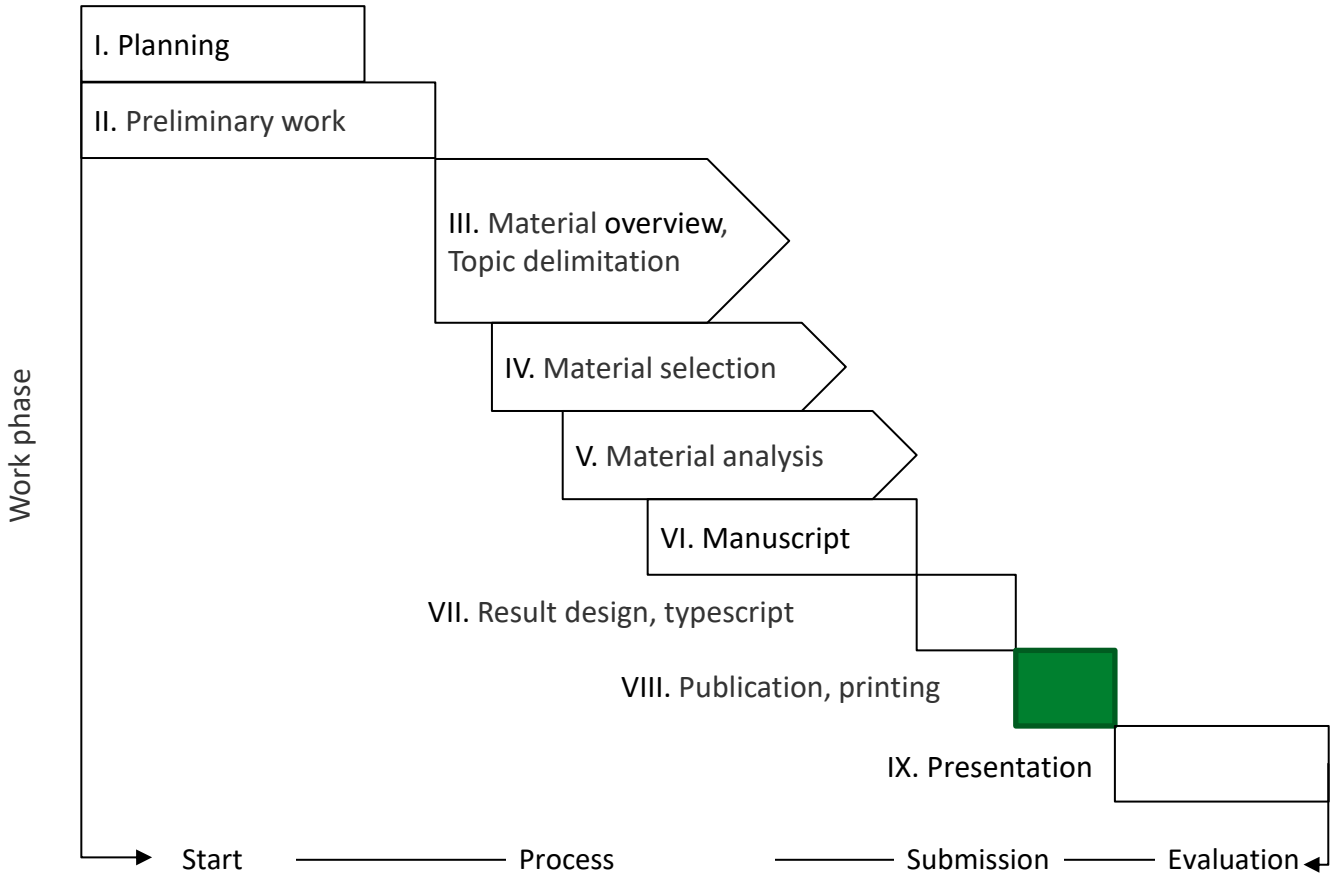
Prof. Dr. Klaus Möller

für

- Seminararbeiten
- Abschlussarbeiten (Bachelor, Master)

1. **Reihenfolge und Bestandteile einer Arbeit**
2. **Form der Arbeit**
3. **Form der Gliederung**
4. **Aufbau des Abbildungs-, Abkürzungs- und Tabellenverzeichnis**
5. **Zitierweise im Text**
6. **Quellenangaben in Fussnoten**
7. **Inhalt des Anhangs**
8. **Aufbau des Literaturverzeichnisses**
9. **Hinweise zur Nutzung von Internetquellen**
10. **Hinweise zur Literaturrecherche**
11. **Unterstützende Literatur**
12. **Erklärung für Abschlussarbeiten**
13. **Inhalt und Gestaltung des Deckblatts einer Übungs- oder Seminararbeit**
14. **Inhalt und Gestaltung des Deckblatts einer Abschlussarbeit (Bachelor- oder Masterarbeit)**

Table of contents: Phases of the scientific work process



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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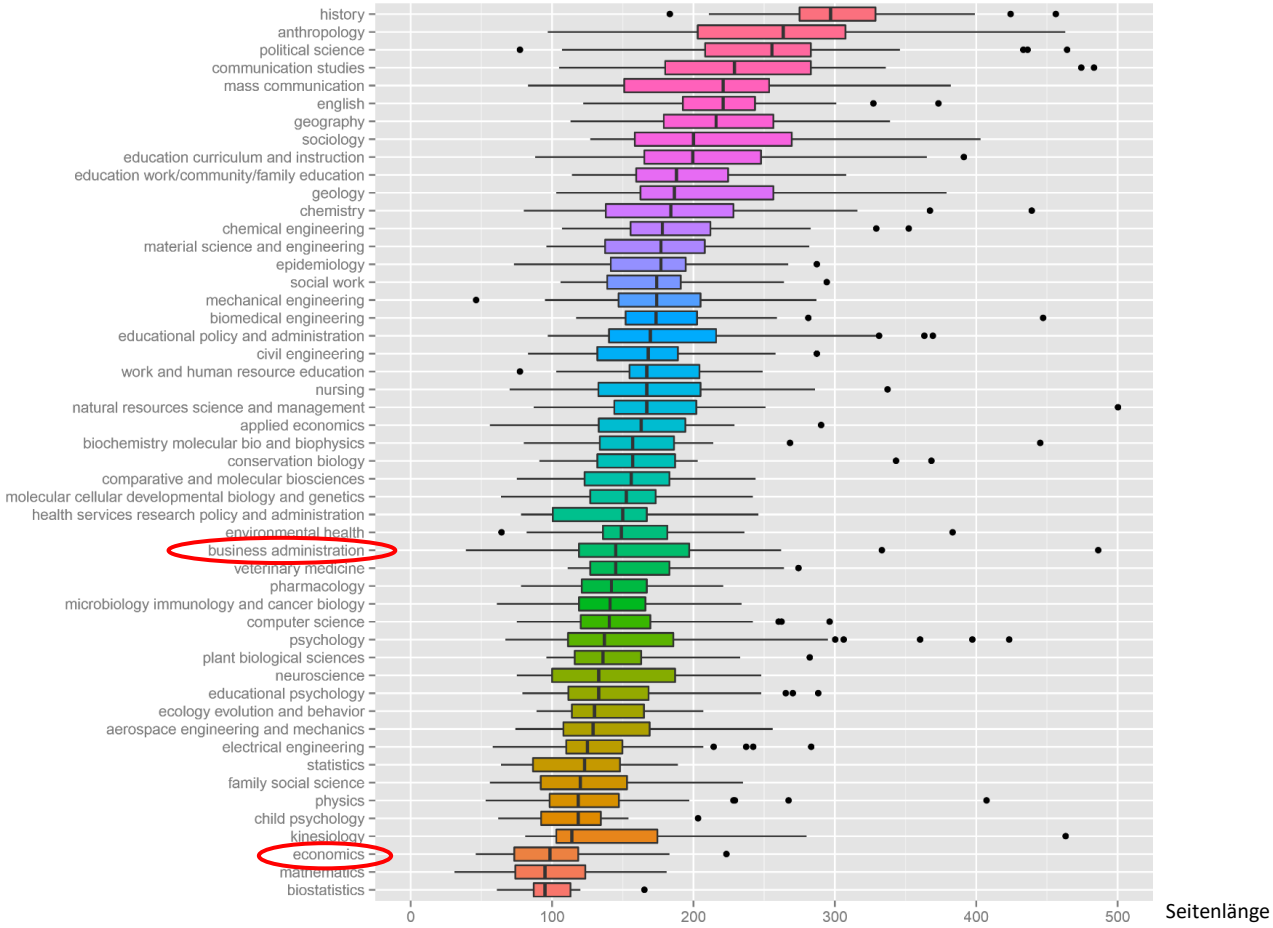
University of St.Gallen

VIII. Publication, printing: dissertation lengths across different disciplines



http://beckmw.files.wordpress.com/2013/04/pop_box2.pdf

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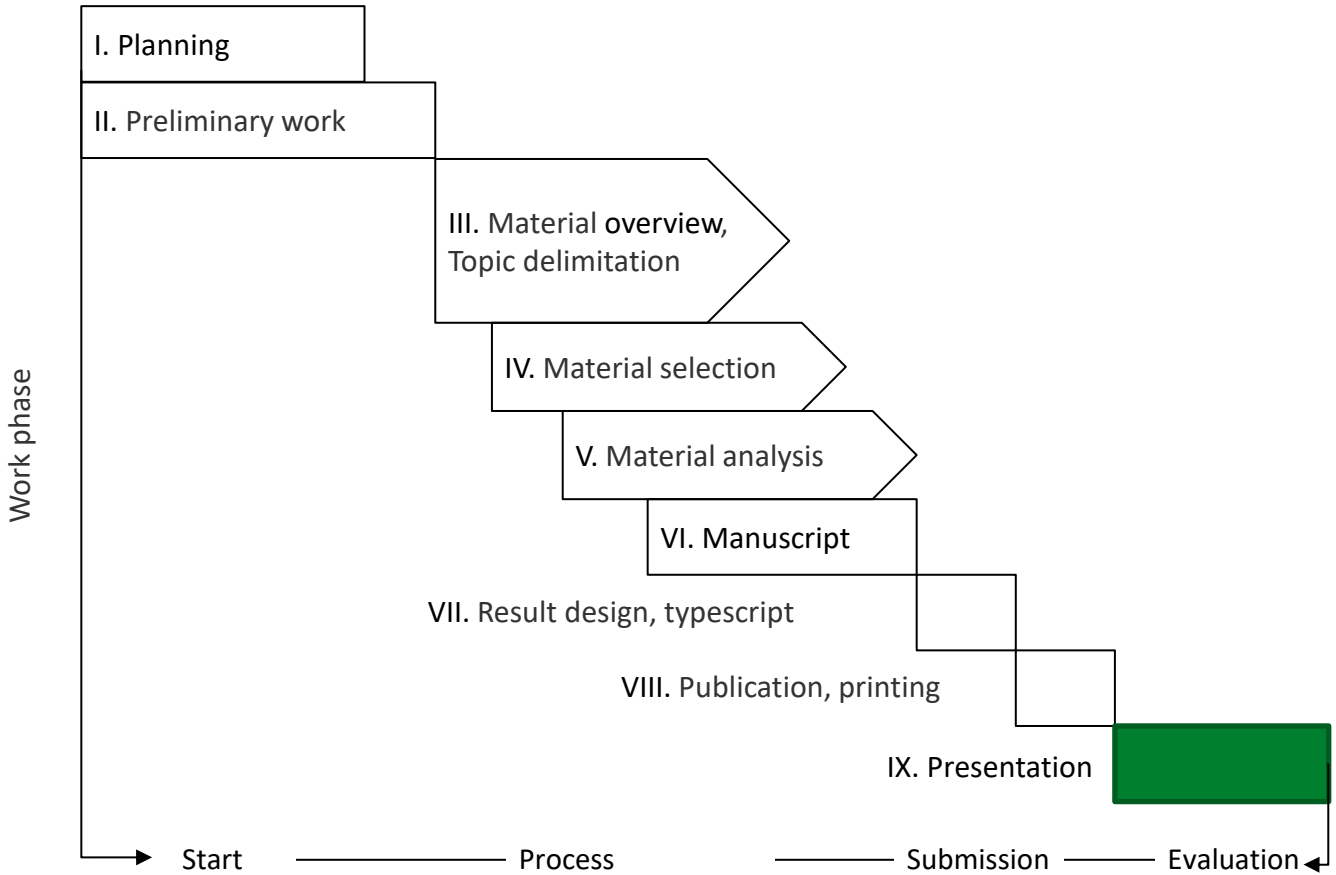
Table of contents: Phases of the scientific work process



Theisen, M. R. (2013), Wissenschaftliches Arbeiten, 16. Aufl., München 2013, S. 39

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